

# Preparing for equitable family and community engagement through home visiting: linking culturally responsive/sustaining pedagogy and developmental frameworks

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## Abstract

This manuscript examines how home visiting by educators aligns with and informs culturally responsive and sustaining pedagogy (CR-SP) through the lens of developmental theory. Drawing on a synthesis of multiple qualitative studies, we analyze evidence of home visiting's influence on four dimensions of CR-SP: teachers' beliefs, dispositions, instructional practices, and integration of family and community knowledge. We find

the strongest alignment between home visiting and teacher beliefs, including enhanced self-reflection, cultural competence, and asset-based thinking. While evidence of impact on responsive instructional practices is emerging, findings show limited influence on teachers' sociopolitical consciousness, curriculum adaptation, or integration of family knowledge into classroom environments. To guide our analysis, we apply asset-based educational frameworks alongside developmental theories, including Bronfenbrenner's ecological systems theory, Vygotsky's sociocultural theory, and developmental systems theory. This interdisciplinary approach highlights home visiting as a potentially powerful relational and developmental bridge between families and schools, while also underscoring the need for structural supports—such as targeted professional learning, reflection tools, and policy guidance—to realize its full promise. We conclude with implications for theory, research, and practice, calling for more robust and longitudinal inquiry into how home visiting can support equity-driven, developmentally aligned teaching across varied educational contexts.

**Keywords:** Classroom practice, Culturally responsive pedagogy, Family engagement, Home visiting, Teacher beliefs

Fostering equitable family engagement requires schools and teachers to implement a repertoire of responsive practices (Mapp & Bergman, 2021). Assets-framed, relationship-building home visiting (also called family-centered home visiting) is one such family engagement practice. This type of home visiting practice is intended to center families' stories and assets, build relationships between educators and families, and inform asset-based teaching (Moll et al., 1992; Park & Paulick, 2021; Paulick et al., 2024; Venkateswaran et al., 2018). There is evidence that family-centered home visiting is associated with families' increased involvement with school, children's improved academic performance, and shifts in teachers' beliefs and practices (McKnight et al., 2019; Meyer et al., 2011; Sheldon & Jung, 2018; Venkateswaran et al., 2018).

Home visiting programs more broadly have a long history in the United States. Such programs have taken a variety of forms over the years, but they have primarily centered practitioners' expertise, supplementing or supplanting families' caregiving practices. For example, home visitors were sent into low-income, immigrant homes at the turn of the 20th century with the goal of "Americanizing" mothers' caretaking and homemaking (Bhavnagri & Krolikowski, 2000; Roibal, 2016). Similarly, programs since the 1960s have involved public health workers and social workers visiting homes in order to provide services and education within the families' space (National Home Visiting Resource Center). These types of home visits that center practitioners' knowledge continue to occur, with an emphasis on the program goals and provider's expertise, rather than explicitly foregrounding the cultural and linguistic assets, knowledge, and experiences of families (e.g., Grindal, 2016;

Jacobs, et al., 2016; Nievar et al., 2018; Peacock, 2013; Walsh et al., 2019). Within the same era, family-centered home visiting began. These assets-framed, relationship-building teacher home visits have aims that are different from home visits conducted by public health workers or social workers. Specifically, assets-framed ethnographic home visits are intended to inform educators about families (e.g., Moll et al., 1992); relationship-building home visits are intended to build trusting collaborations between educators and families (e.g., Venkateswaran et al., 2018). Visits that combine those two aims center families' stories and, in so doing, build rapport (Paulick et al., 2024).

Over the past 25 years, family-centered home visiting by pK–12 teachers has gradually gained traction across the United States. Despite this growing interest, research specifically focused on teachers conducting home visits remains limited, particularly in terms of how assets-framed home visiting might impact teaching practice. Qualitative studies, including ethnographies and case studies of locally developed family-centered home visiting initiatives, have employed teacher reflections, surveys, and interviews as primary data sources (Johnson, 2014; Lin & Bates, 2010; McIntyre et al., 2001; Meyer et al., 2011; Peralta-Nash, 2003; Whyte & Karabon, 2016). These studies highlight that while teachers often express apprehension about entering families' homes and may initially possess narrow views of family assets (Whyte & Karabon, 2016), both educators and families tend to view home visits as beneficial (Lin & Bates, 2010; McIntyre et al., 2001; Peralta-Nash, 2003). For example, Meyer and Mann examined relationship-building home visits conducted by 26 rural early elementary teachers. Their pre- and post-survey analysis revealed that teachers reported improved communication and stronger relationships with families along with a deeper understanding of the children and their home environments. A replication study by Meyer et al. (2011), involving 17 original and 11 additional participants, confirmed these findings 5 years later.

To build on this emerging work and guide our analysis, we turn to a set of theoretical frameworks that foreground equity, cultural responsiveness, and developmental alignment between home and school. These frameworks help us examine not only *whether* home visiting supports equitable education, but *how* it does so, and where its potential remains unrealized.



## 1. Theoretical frameworks

Our study is grounded in a combination of asset-based pedagogical frameworks and developmental psychology theories that, together, support a holistic understanding of how family-centered home visiting can inform

and enhance equitable, culturally responsive educational practices. The primary frameworks that inform asset-based teaching include Culturally Responsive Teaching (Gay, 2010), Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014; Powell et al., 2016), and Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy (Paris, 2012). These approaches center students', families', and communities' cultural identities, values, and knowledge systems as fundamental resources for learning. They outline core beliefs (e.g., understanding one's positionality and engaging in cultural self-reflection), dispositions (e.g., high expectations and sociopolitical consciousness), and practices (e.g., student-centered instruction, responsive discourse, and family collaboration) that educators can enact to disrupt inequities and promote historically marginalized students' success. We also attend to the dimension of integration, which reflects the alignment of beliefs, dispositions, and practices in ways that support students' community-based identities, heritage languages, and critical awareness of power and oppression. Taken together, they are Culturally Relevant/Responsive/Sustaining Pedagogy (CR-SP).

To complement this educational lens, we incorporate insights from developmental psychology. Bronfenbrenner's bioecological systems theory (1979) emphasizes the importance of interconnected environments in shaping children's development. In particular, the mesosystem—the interaction between home and school—is a critical site for fostering consistent, responsive developmental support. Home visits serve as a direct mechanism for strengthening this mesosystem, allowing teachers to engage with families within their own cultural contexts and deepen mutual understanding. We also view learning and development as culturally mediated and rooted in social interactions (Vygotsky, 1978). Teachers' participation in family-centered home visits allows them to better recognize and build on the cultural practices, languages, and values that shape students' development outside of school. This awareness supports instructional practices that are not only developmentally appropriate but culturally meaningful, helping students learn within their zone of proximal development through culturally congruent support. We also draw on developmental systems theory (Lerner, 2006), which emphasizes dynamic, reciprocal relations between individuals and their ecological contexts. From this perspective, optimal development occurs when children's individual strengths and characteristics are supported by environments that reflect and respond to their cultural and social realities. Family-centered home visiting can be seen as an intentional effort to improve the developmental alignment between school and home, creating conditions where families' values and practices are recognized,

respected, and integrated into classroom learning. This alignment supports not only children's social and emotional growth but also fosters cognitive and language development, as children experience consistency between home and school that reinforces meaning-making, narrative structures, and concept development in culturally congruent ways. When teachers incorporate what they learn from home visits into instruction, they are better positioned to build on students' existing knowledge and linguistic repertoires, which is especially important for multilingual learners and children from culturally diverse backgrounds.

Finally, our work is informed by [Mapp and Bergman \(2021\)](#) "More Liberatory Approach to Family Engagement," which identifies equitable engagement as relational, collaborative, culturally responsive, and rooted in mutual respect. Their model emphasizes that achieving such engagement requires intentional, reflective work by educators to confront bias, build trust, and truly listen to families and communities. Together, these theoretical frameworks illuminate how family-centered home visiting can serve as both a developmental and pedagogical intervention—strengthening teacher beliefs and practices, improving family-school relationships, and ultimately supporting children's academic and social development in culturally sustaining ways.



## **2. Literature review**

### **2.1 Conceptual intersection between home visiting and CR-SP**

Most teachers in the U.S. are from dominant cultural and social identity groups, and most families are from historically-marginalized groups ([NCES, 2024](#)). This results in power differentials between schools and homes that can lead to mistrust between families and teachers ([Hong, 2020](#); [Ishimaru, 2019](#)). Family-centered home visits are intended to build relational trust between educators and families. Relational trust across school communities, according to [Bryk and Schneider \(2002\)](#), requires mutual respect, a belief in the competence of others, personal regard, and integrity. All of those elements take time, proximity, and opportunities to connect safely, and family-centered home visits provide those opportunities ([Paulick et al., 2023, 2024](#)). In a study of family-centered home visits between kindergarten and second-grade teachers and their students' families, [Paulick et al. \(2024\)](#) found that teachers can employ rapport-building strategies that connect them with families as fellow human beings and as competent, child-centered

professionals. That rapport-building led to the kinds of substantive discussions that are the basis for trust building. Ideally, family-centered home visits would translate into what [Mapp and Bergman \(2021\)](#) describe as liberatory family engagement, situating families and educators as equal collaborators with different expertise and positioning that collaboration as powerful enough to dismantle systemic inequities.

Research has also shown that family-focused home visits contribute positively to teachers' attitudes toward children and families, foster more effective disciplinary and communication practices ([McKnight et al., 2019](#)), and enhance students' academic performance, attendance, and family involvement ([Sheldon & Jung, 2018](#); [Wright et al., 2018](#)). Furthermore, family-centered home visits have been shown to significantly influence teachers' beliefs, promoting greater cultural responsiveness, reduced bias, and increased recognition of family strengths and assets ([McKnight et al., 2022](#)). By focusing intentionally on building genuine relationships, home visits have the potential to transform educators' perceptions, moving them away from deficit-oriented views and toward recognizing and valuing the strengths within families and students, thereby fostering effective instructional approaches and enhancing meaningful collaboration between schools and families ([Baeder, 2010](#); [McKnight et al., 2022](#)). Moreover, evidence suggests that students who experienced family-centered home visits demonstrated reduced chronic absenteeism and improved student performance in ELA and math ([Sheldon & Jung, 2018](#)). Notably, the potential benefits extended beyond students and families who directly experienced home visiting, as students attending schools with at least 10 percent of families participating in home visits were both less likely to be chronically absent and more likely to reach proficiency on standardized ELA tests ([Sheldon & Jung, 2018](#)). These findings were across elementary and secondary schools, indicating that it is developmentally appropriate to enact family-centered home visits across children's and adolescents' schooling.

Family-centered home visits can inform asset-based teaching practices. Asset-based teaching requires that teachers see and understand the Funds of Knowledge ([Moll et al., 1992](#)), Community Cultural Wealth ([Yosso, 2005](#)), and cultural models (e.g., ([Gallimore & Goldenberg, 2001](#))) that families possess. Those assets are the historical and contemporary values and skills that are passed on to children, and values and skills vary widely across families. Furthermore, when teachers are exposed only to mainstream values and skills, it may be challenging for them to see and honor the values and skills that families with marginalized identities possess. For example, mainstream

American culture places a value on competition, while many families teach the value of collaboration to their children. Paulick et al. (2022) found that home visiting teachers can use artifacts in the home to elicit families' stories, skills, and cultural models. Knowing about those assets provides essential information for enacting culturally responsive/relevant/sustaining pedagogy (Gay, 2010; Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014; Paris, 2012; Powell et al., 2016).

While modest, the research base for the impact of family-centered home visits on educators' attitudes and beliefs is considerably more robust than the research base on the impact of these visits on educators' teaching practices. There is empirical work indicating that family-centered home visits may fall short of realizing culturally sustaining tenets (Park & Paulick, 2021) and may lead to surface-level impacts on teaching (Szech, 2022), particularly without substantial professional learning opportunities before and after the visits. Without those professional learning opportunities, power imbalances persist, teachers may be blind to families' assets, and translating assets into pedagogical practice is difficult.

Overall, the research on the relationship between family-centered home visiting and teachers' beliefs, dispositions, and practices lags considerably behind the practice of family-centered home visiting. This conceptual study asked: *How does home visiting support and enable CR-SP? Which CR-SP beliefs, dispositions, and practices are not served by family-centered home visiting? What is left to know and do at the intersection of family-centered home visiting and CR-SP?*



### 3. Methods and data sources

With the aim of conceptually analyzing how family-centered home visiting aligns with and advances CR-SP principles, we first reviewed existing CR-SP frameworks across foundational literature (Gay, 2010; Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014; Paris, 2012; Powell et al., 2016). This initial examination identified four critical dimensions of CR-SP:

1. **Beliefs:** Teachers' beliefs involve a deep awareness and understanding of their own identities, the development of cultural competence, and a commitment to ongoing reflective practices that examine culture and identity, thereby laying the essential foundation for culturally responsive and equitable teaching.
2. **Dispositions:** Teachers' dispositions, characterized by maintaining high expectations for student academic success while demonstrating a steadfast commitment to nurturing students' sociopolitical consciousness, empower learners to engage critically with social issues.

3. Practices: Teachers' practices that encompass the ability to design and adapt curricula and assessments in ways that are flexible, responsive, and student-centered, ensuring equitable access to dominant cultural norms and language, while also engaging in culturally responsive discourse and actively collaborating with families to support children's learning and development.
4. Integration: Teachers' integration involves the seamless interplay between teachers' dispositions and practices, actively supporting students in preserving community and heritage languages, centering families' and communities' narratives and traditions, and critically examining practices that may reinforce oppression or hegemonic norms, ultimately cultivating an inclusive and empowering educational environment.

Together, these four dimensions—beliefs, dispositions, practices, and integration—offer a comprehensive framework for understanding culturally responsive and sustaining pedagogy (CR-SP). They serve as an analytic lens through which we examine how home visiting may influence educators' orientations and practice toward equity in diverse educational contexts

We then employed qualitative content analysis techniques to systematically identify overarching categories that capture the key findings across our studies on home visiting. Through iterative coding, categorization, and synthesis of findings, we identified six overarching themes describing how home visiting aligns with and informs CR-SP principles:

1. Differentiation: Family-centered home visiting informs differentiation of curricula, instruction, and assessment by revealing the strengths, interests, and cultural contexts of children and families.
2. Understanding: Family-centered home visiting broadens teachers' understanding of children's and families' identities, values, and lived experiences, thus supporting culturally responsive relationships.
3. Professional Development: Effective implementation of home visiting to truly center families require targeted professional training for most teachers.
4. Efficacy: Teachers' self-efficacy in culturally responsive and sustaining practices increases significantly when training is combined with hands-on home visiting experiences and structured reflection opportunities.
5. Asset Integration: Teachers effectively leverage artifacts within families' homes during visits to elicit rich narratives, histories, and cultural practices, deepening culturally responsive engagement.
6. Dialogue: Ideally, school-based conferences serve as contexts primarily for educational progress discussions, while home visits uniquely offer



space for child- and family-focused dialogue centered on cultural assets and community contexts.

These six themes illustrate the multifaceted ways in which home visiting can support and extend the principles of CR-SP, from shaping instructional approaches to deepening relational and cultural understanding. Together, they provide a nuanced foundation for examining how home visiting operates as a practice that fosters equity-oriented teaching and meaningful school-family partnerships.

Finally, to facilitate a detailed comparison between CR-SP frameworks and family-centered home visiting practices, we developed a comparative matrix. This analytic tool enabled us to explicitly map home visiting practices onto the identified CR-SP components, clearly highlighting areas of alignment and identifying existing gaps or areas requiring further development or research attention.



## **4. Results and implications**

We found evidence of alignment between the CR-SP framework and the themes representing the evidence from our studies of home visiting (Table 1). Overall, evidence from the research literature to date indicates that family-centered home visiting is associated with teachers' beliefs to a large extent and their dispositions somewhat. There is some evidence that home visiting supports teachers' responsive discourse, but otherwise there is not yet a body of evidence demonstrating the impact of home visiting on teaching practice.

### **4.1 Beliefs**

Our findings suggest that family-centered home visiting supports teachers' understanding of their positionality, enhances their sense of self-efficacy for engaging culturally competently with students, and facilitates an ongoing process of self-reflection. Additionally, home visiting appears to promote an asset-based mindset by encouraging teachers to recognize the strengths and cultural wealth within families and communities while also challenging biases and deficit perspectives. Our analyses further highlight that targeted professional development explicitly addressing the goals, purposes, and effective implementation of home visits appears essential. Teachers require structured preparation and ongoing training to clearly communicate home-visiting purposes to families, effectively center family perspectives, and optimize culturally responsive interactions.

**Table 1** Matrix exploring alignment between CR-SP and the themes from home visiting studies.

|                                                                 | Findings                                                                        |                                                                                                              |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                 | Differentiation                                                                 | Understanding                                                                                                | Professional development                                                                               | Efficacy                                                                                        | Asset integration                                                              | Dialogue                                                                                                 |
| Culturally Relevant/Responsive/<br>Sustaining Teaching Tenets   | Home visiting informs differentiation of curricula, instruction, and assessment | Home visiting broadens/nuances teachers' understandings of who children and families are and what they value | Training necessary for teachers to center families; families also need to be made aware of the purpose | Training, hands-on practice and reflection is associated with increased self-efficacy for CR-SP | Teachers can leverage artifacts in families' homes to elicit families' stories | Conferences for school-focused discussions; home visits for child-focused and family-focused discussions |
| <b>BELIEFS</b>                                                  |                                                                                 |                                                                                                              |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |
| Teacher understanding of their own identities and positionality |                                                                                 |                                                                                                              | ✓                                                                                                      | ✓                                                                                               |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |
| Teacher's cultural competence                                   |                                                                                 | ✓                                                                                                            | ✓                                                                                                      | ✓                                                                                               | ✓                                                                              | ✓                                                                                                        |
| Teacher's ongoing self-reflection                               |                                                                                 | ✓                                                                                                            | ✓                                                                                                      | ✓                                                                                               | ✓                                                                              |                                                                                                          |
| <b>DISPOSITIONS</b>                                             |                                                                                 |                                                                                                              |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |
| High expectations for academic success of students              | ✓                                                                               |                                                                                                              |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |
| Commitment to developing students' sociopolitical consciousness |                                                                                 |                                                                                                              |                                                                                                        |                                                                                                 |                                                                                |                                                                                                          |

**PRACTICES**

Utilizing and modifying curricula and assessments that are flexible, responsive, and student-centered while still providing access to dominant culture and language

Engaging in responsive discourse

Collaborating with families in service of children

✓

✓

✓

✓

**INTEGRATION**

Supporting students in maintaining their community/heritage languages and cultural models

Centering children's, families', communities' stories, ways of knowing/being, practices

Interrogating and critiquing youth and community practices that perpetuate oppression and hegemony

✓

✓

## 4.2 Dispositions

We found limited evidence that family-centered home visiting helps teachers develop high expectations for students' academic success. However, there was no supporting evidence that home visiting promotes teachers' commitment to developing students' sociopolitical consciousness. These gaps indicate a need for further research to explore whether and how visiting might empower families to engage as equal partners in their educational process, thereby potentially influencing teachers' dispositions over time.

## 4.3 Practices

We found evidence that family-centered home visiting supports teachers in engaging in responsive discourse with families, which contributes to relationship building and trust. However, there was limited evidence that it aids in utilizing and modifying curricula and assessments to be flexible, responsive, and student-centered while providing equitable access to dominant culture and language. Similarly, although teachers sometimes leverage artifacts within families' homes to elicit rich narratives and cultural practices, there is limited evidence that home visiting consistently fosters broader collaboration with families outside of the home environment or leads to changes in classroom environments and pedagogy that fully reflect these insights. Additionally, our findings indicate that family-centered home visits serve a distinct role separate from school-based conferences. While school-based conferences primarily address students' educational progress, home visits uniquely facilitate deeper, culturally responsive dialogues, specifically oriented towards understanding family strengths, values, cultural assets, and community contexts.

## 4.4 Integration

We found limited evidence that family-centered home visiting leads teachers to center children's families' and communities' stories, ways of knowing, and practices. We also found no evidence that home visiting fosters teachers' integration of practices that support maintaining students' community/heritage languages or the critical examination of practices that perpetuate oppression and hegemony. Future studies should examine not only these integrative practices but also the potential long-term impact of assets-framed, relationship-building home visiting on sustained teacher growth, including the development of community partnerships and shared resource models that could enhance culturally responsive and sustaining education.



## 5. Significance

This study examined how family-centered home visiting practices align with and inform culturally responsive and sustaining pedagogy (CR-SP), with the goal of identifying where such visits support teachers' beliefs, dispositions, and instructional practices that promote equity in education. Despite the growing use of home visiting to strengthen family-school partnerships, relatively little empirical work has explored its connections to CR-SP or its role in shaping teacher development. Our analysis across multiple studies revealed strong evidence that family-centered home visiting positively influences teachers' beliefs—particularly their self-reflection, cultural competence, and asset-based mindsets. We found more limited evidence of impact on teachers' dispositions and classroom practices, and minimal evidence that home visiting fosters the deeper integration of culturally sustaining pedagogies in everyday instruction.

Our findings indicate that family-centered home visiting can significantly enhance teachers' understanding of their positionality, self-efficacy in cultural competence, and foster an ongoing process of self-reflection, all of which are crucial for implementing CR-SP. However, the limited evidence in promoting high expectations for academic success and the lack of evidence in developing sociopolitical consciousness, flexible curriculum adaptation, and deeper family collaboration highlight critical areas for further research and professional development. Addressing these gaps is essential for maximizing the impact of home visiting on educational equity and ensuring that teaching practices comprehensively support diverse student populations.

Our inquiry was guided by a combination of asset-based pedagogical frameworks and developmental psychology theories, each of which positions families' and communities' cultural knowledge and practices as central to children's learning and growth. We drew on Culturally Responsive Teaching (Gay, 2010), Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014), and Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy (Paris, 2012), which collectively emphasize educators' beliefs, dispositions, and practices that honor and incorporate students' lived experiences. This study contributes to these frameworks by illuminating how home visiting can serve as a relational entry point into this work—supporting the foundational beliefs and perspectives that underlie CR-SP, even when practice-level transformation is less evident. To complement these educational frameworks, we incorporated insights from developmental psychology, particularly Bronfenbrenner's bioecological

systems theory (1979), Vygotsky's sociocultural theory (1978), and developmental systems theory (Lerner, 2006). These perspectives emphasize the critical role of social interactions, cultural contexts, and aligned systems in supporting children's holistic development. Home visiting offers a promising avenue for strengthening the mesosystem—the connections between home and school—and for creating more consistent, culturally aligned experiences that support children's social, cognitive, and linguistic development. Together, these frameworks provide a robust foundation for understanding how home visiting can function as both a developmental and pedagogical intervention aimed at advancing educational equity.

## 5.1 Beliefs: foundational shifts toward culturally responsive practice

Our findings demonstrate that home visiting consistently supports shifts in teachers' beliefs, particularly in ways that align with culturally responsive and sustaining pedagogical frameworks. Across studies, teachers who participated in home visits described increased self-awareness, deeper cultural competence, and a clearer understanding of their own positionality in relation to the families they serve. These reflections often emerged through direct, relational encounters with families in their home environments, where teachers confronted and challenged their assumptions, recognized the strengths and cultural wealth present in students' lives, and began to view families as critical partners in education.

This evidence aligns strongly with the core belief components outlined in Culturally Responsive Teaching (Gay, 2010), Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014), and Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy (Paris, 2012), all of which position teacher self-reflection and cultural awareness as foundational to equity-oriented practice. By engaging directly with families in non-school settings, teachers are afforded opportunities to see students within the context of their homes, languages, traditions, and values—insights that are central to asset-based teaching.

From a developmental perspective, these relational experiences reflect the kind of culturally grounded, context-sensitive learning emphasized in both Vygotsky's sociocultural theory and Bronfenbrenner's ecological systems model. Vygotsky (1978) argued that learning is socially mediated and culturally situated; home visiting enables teachers to better understand the sociocultural tools children bring to the classroom, improving their capacity to scaffold instruction within students' zones of proximal development.

Similarly, [Bronfenbrenner \(1979\)](#) emphasized the importance of strong mesosystem connections—those between home and school—in supporting child development. Home visiting functions as a direct mechanism to strengthen this mesosystem, fostering developmental continuity and mutual understanding between educators and families.

The role of professional development is also crucial in amplifying the belief-level impacts of home visiting. Our findings suggest that when home visiting is paired with structured training—particularly training that helps teachers reflect on bias, define the purpose of visits, and learn strategies for culturally responsive interaction—teachers are more likely to engage in meaningful self-reflection and to recognize the cultural assets within families. In the absence of this intentional preparation, opportunities for learning may be limited or misdirected. Thus, effective professional development is not simply a supplement to home visiting but a necessary condition for ensuring that visits promote shifts in beliefs that lay the groundwork for deeper changes in practice.

## **5.2 Dispositions: building trust in the absence of critical engagement**

While our findings indicate that family-centered home visiting can contribute to shifts in teachers' beliefs, there is more limited evidence that it influences teachers' dispositions—particularly their expectations for students' academic success and their commitment to developing students' sociopolitical consciousness. A few studies suggest that home visits may help educators recognize students' strengths in ways that could support higher expectations, but this shift was inconsistently documented and rarely articulated explicitly by teachers. Even more notably, we found no evidence that home visiting alone cultivates dispositions aligned with sociopolitical consciousness, such as a commitment to helping students recognize and challenge injustice in their lives and communities.

This absence is significant when considered in light of culturally relevant and sustaining pedagogical models, which emphasize sociopolitical consciousness as a critical dimension of equity-oriented teaching ([Ladson-Billings, 1995, 2014](#); [Paris, 2012](#)). While home visiting creates conditions for educators to connect with families, it may not provide the structural or conceptual tools necessary to support critical reflection on systemic inequities, power dynamics, or educators' own roles in upholding or challenging oppressive systems. In other words, relationship-building alone

does not automatically prompt educators to engage with questions of justice or to translate personal insight into a broader critical consciousness.

There are several potential reasons why home visiting, as currently implemented, may fall short of fostering these deeper dispositions. Most notably, the practice often lacks built-in reflection tools or prompts that center justice, equity, or power. Without guided opportunities to examine structural inequalities or to interrogate how cultural knowledge intersects with educational opportunity, teachers may form stronger personal connections with families without critically examining the larger systems shaping those families' experiences. In the absence of this critical framing, educators may unintentionally reinforce colorblind or individualistic interpretations of equity, rather than developing the sociopolitical awareness necessary to engage in transformative practice.

These findings point to a clear need for professional learning experiences that go beyond relational skill-building. While training in effective communication and cultural responsiveness is essential, it may require opportunities for critical reflection, structural analysis, and engagement with the historical and political contexts that shape educational inequity. Educators need time and support to explore how their positionality, school policies, and classroom practices relate to broader systems of power. Integrating this kind of justice-oriented professional development with home visiting could help ensure that teachers not only build trust with families but also develop the dispositions necessary to support students as agents of change in their own lives and communities.

### **5.3 Practice: building relationships but needing scaffolds**

Our findings suggest that home visiting supports one particularly meaningful CR-SP-aligned practice: responsive discourse. Teachers who engaged in home visits often described improved communication with families, increased empathy, and a deeper capacity to listen and respond to families' perspectives. This form of culturally responsive dialogue fosters trust and affirms family voices, positioning teachers as learners and families as experts in their children's lives. These relational practices reflect a core tenet of culturally responsive pedagogy and represent a concrete way in which home visiting can shape daily educator–family interactions.

Beyond these relational gains, however, the evidence is more limited when it comes to the influence of home visiting on curriculum design, assessment strategies, and classroom pedagogy. While teachers often



report gaining valuable insights into students' cultural contexts, interests, and strengths through home visits, few studies to date have systematically examined how, or to what extent, these insights are applied to instructional practice. It remains unclear whether this reflects a gap in teacher enactment or simply a gap in research focused on instructional transfer.

Developmental systems theory (Lerner, 2006) provides a helpful framework for interpreting this limitation. From this perspective, learning and development are optimized when there is alignment across a child's ecological contexts. In the case of home visiting, teachers gain contextually rich knowledge about children and families—but without institutional supports or pedagogical tools to guide application, that knowledge may not consistently transfer into the classroom. Even if educators are motivated to apply what they learn, structural barriers—such as rigid curricula, lack of planning time, or absence of collaborative support—may prevent that knowledge from shaping teaching practices in sustained ways.

These findings point to a need for caution in assuming that stronger relationships with families will naturally lead to more culturally responsive instruction. Home visits may create the foundation for asset-based teaching, but their full potential is unlikely to be realized without intentional scaffolding. Schools must invest in professional development, curricular flexibility, and planning structures that explicitly support the translation of relational insight into practice. At the same time, more research is needed to explore how and when this kind of transfer occurs, and what conditions best support it. Strengthening this alignment between relationship-building and classroom implementation is critical to ensuring that home visiting functions not only as a tool for connection, but also as a lever for equity-driven teaching.

## **5.4 Integration: toward deep alignment of home and school contexts**

Among the four CR-SP dimensions examined in this study, integration emerged as the area with the least evidence of alignment. While teachers often reported gaining meaningful insights into students' families, cultures, and home environments through family-centered home visits, we found minimal documentation that these insights translated into sustained, systemic shifts in curriculum, instruction, or school policy. It is important to note, however, that this lack of evidence may reflect limitations in the current research base rather than a definitive absence of integrative practice. Few

studies to date have explicitly examined how teachers incorporate family and community knowledge into classroom environments over time, leaving open important questions about what forms of integration may be occurring but remain unstudied or undocumented.

That said, our findings suggest that even when relational insight is achieved, teachers may lack the time, tools, or institutional support to meaningfully apply what they learn in structurally transformative ways. Integration—defined here as the alignment of beliefs, dispositions, and practices with families’ cultural knowledge, community languages, and local epistemologies—likely requires more than relational exposure. It demands shifts in the broader systems that shape teaching and learning: curriculum and assessment frameworks, language policies, professional development opportunities, and teacher preparation programs. Without these structural supports, even the most well-intentioned educators may struggle to translate family knowledge into classroom practice.

From a developmental perspective, the absence of sustained integration may hinder alignment between children’s home environments and formal learning contexts. Sociocultural theory (Vygotsky, 1978) emphasizes that development is shaped through culturally mediated interactions, while developmental systems theory underscores the importance of coherence across ecological settings. Without mechanisms for integrating family knowledge into instruction, the potential for developmental alignment across home and school remains limited. As we argue that integrating family and community knowledge into educational practice is not peripheral but essential to advancing equitable developmental outcomes—especially for students from historically marginalized communities (Palacios & Paulick, 2024).

These findings point to an important direction for both research and practice. Family-centered home visiting may be a powerful entry point for building relational trust and cultural understanding, but realizing its full potential will require systems-level support. Future studies should investigate how, when, and under what conditions integration occurs—and how schools can create environments that actively support the transfer of family and community knowledge into the heart of classroom learning.

## **5.5 Revisiting theory, policy, and practice: the promise and limits of home visiting**

Our findings suggest that home visiting holds significant promise as both a developmental and pedagogical intervention, particularly in shaping

teachers' beliefs and laying a foundation for culturally responsive practice. Across studies, home visits helped teachers reflect on their own positionality, engage more empathetically with families, and adopt a more asset-based view of students' cultural contexts and experiences. These shifts align with central tenets of CR-SP and reflect the kind of contextual sensitivity emphasized in developmental theories. When teachers gain a deeper understanding of the cultural tools, languages, and values children bring to school, they are better positioned to support learning within students' developmental zones and to strengthen coherence across home and school environments (Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Palacios & Paulick, 2024; Vygotsky, 1978).

Yet, while home visiting fosters meaningful relational insight, we found less evidence that it prompts transformation in teachers' dispositions or instructional practices—particularly around sociopolitical consciousness, curriculum design, and sustained integration of family knowledge into classroom environments. This limited impact may reflect both real implementation gaps and limitations in the current evidence base, as few studies have directly examined how insights from home visits are—or are not—carried into classroom teaching. Still, the pattern points to a core theoretical and practical insight: relational exposure is a key component, but alone it is not sufficient for structural change. For home visiting to fully support CR-SP and developmental alignment, it must be embedded within broader systems of support.

This finding surfaces a critical tension: family-centered home visiting is often framed as a strategy to build relational trust, yet it does not inherently cultivate critical consciousness or lead to systemic shifts in pedagogy or policy. While teachers may reflect on their own biases and build empathy—which we acknowledge as key components of family-centered, assets-based, relationship-building home visits—these insights often remain at the level of individual reflection rather than extending into curriculum, assessment, or instructional reform. To move beyond this limitation, we argue for the development of professional learning that intentionally links home visiting to equity-focused instructional planning. This includes embedding structured reflection protocols, prompts for culturally sustaining curriculum design, and opportunities for teachers to collectively make sense of what they learn during visits. Policy and institutional supports may be essential: teachers need time, guidance, and frameworks that help them apply relational knowledge in meaningful ways. Moreover, schools and districts should distinguish clearly between the purposes of home visits and school-based conferences—recognizing that the former creates space for understanding

families' lives, assets, and values, while the latter often centers on academic performance. Clarifying these roles can ensure that home visits are not reduced to compliance activities, but are instead positioned as transformative tools for relational and instructional alignment.

In this way, our findings extend both CR-SP and developmental theory by identifying the conditions under which home visiting can serve as a lever for equity. When supported by intentional professional development and institutional infrastructure, home visiting can help create the alignment between ecological contexts that developmental theories call for, while also advancing the pedagogical commitments central to CR-SP. However, realizing this potential requires a deliberate shift—from treating family-centered home visiting as a relational practice alone to embedding it within a broader vision of culturally sustaining, developmentally aligned schooling.

## **5.6 Toward a more robust evidence base: limitations and areas for future research**

While this study offers important insights into how home visiting aligns with and informs culturally responsive and sustaining pedagogy (CR-SP), several limitations of the current evidence base warrant careful consideration. First, much of the available research is cross-sectional or short-term, limiting our ability to assess the sustained impact of home visiting on teachers' beliefs, dispositions, and practices over time. Longitudinal studies that follow teachers across multiple years are needed to understand whether early shifts in mindset or relational practice lead to deeper instructional transformation and improved student outcomes. Additionally, there is a need for research at the intersection of developmental and educational theory to better understand how home visiting may function differently across age groups and stages of development, as the dynamics of home visiting may shift as children grow older. Adolescents, for example, may play a more active role in guiding the conversation and shaping what is shared during a home visit—similar to the way that parents typically guide interactions for younger children. These developmental differences warrant closer examination even as the overarching goals of home visiting remain consistent: enabling educators to learn from students and families in ways that deepen their understanding, interrupting inequitable power dynamics, and informing culturally responsive and sustaining teaching.

Notably, key areas of teacher development remain underexplored. While our synthesis found evidence of shifts in teacher beliefs, there is limited

research examining how these beliefs are translated into classroom practices—particularly in terms of curricular adaptation, culturally sustaining pedagogy, or differentiated assessment. Likewise, there is a striking absence of research exploring the impact of home visiting on teachers’ sociopolitical consciousness, a central component of CR-SP that relates to educators’ understanding of power, justice, and structural inequity in education. Without attention to this domain, the transformative potential of home visiting remains only partially realized. Additional gaps include the long-term impacts of home visiting on integration—that is, how family and community knowledge is sustained and embedded in instructional practices over time. Few studies have tracked how teachers maintain and evolve their use of family insights in the months and years following a visit. Moreover, there is limited evidence regarding the role of home visiting in supporting multilingual learners or the maintenance of heritage languages, both of which are foundational to culturally sustaining pedagogies and critical for promoting language equity in schools.

To address these gaps, future research should leverage mixed-method designs that combine rich qualitative data with longitudinal quantitative tracking. Studies that document not only teacher reflection but also classroom practice—along with student and family perspectives—would provide a more comprehensive view of how home visiting functions across educational systems. Attending to equity-oriented outcomes, such as sociopolitical awareness, heritage language use, and culturally sustaining instruction, will also be key in evaluating the broader transformative potential of home visiting as both a developmental and pedagogical intervention.



## 6. Conclusion

Family-centered home visiting offers significant promise as a relationship-centered practice that connects families and schools in meaningful, developmentally supportive ways. It can help educators build trust, better understand the cultural and linguistic strengths of students and families, and begin to shift how they see their role in fostering equity. Yet, to fully realize the potential of the CR-SP framework, home visiting must be supported by more than good intentions. Teachers need ongoing professional learning, time for critical reflection, and school-wide systems that help them apply what they learn during visits to their classroom practices. Strengthening the alignment between what teachers come to understand through home visiting and how they teach, assess, and engage

students in the classroom is essential for creating inclusive and excellent learning environments. These findings build on both culturally responsive and developmental theories by showing how home visiting can foster alignment between children's home and school environments while also revealing the systemic supports needed to translate that alignment into lasting educational practice.

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